

Following the initial design, a second round of interviews was conducted with members of the NAU Esports Club, former competitive teammates, and experienced FPS players. This group was intentionally selected for both their familiarity with competitive titles and their ability to critically evaluate systems based on clarity, balance, and competitive depth. The focus of these post-conception interviews was to re-examine the updated game concept after the removal of two major systems: the relic-triggered environmental mechanics and the inclusion of mythological or god-tier characters. Their feedback indicates that these revisions addressed many of the concerns from the initial phase and helped align the game with competitive FPS norms, while also revealing new areas for improvement.

Improvements Observed After Major Concept Revisions

1. Elimination of Relic-Triggered Environmental Changes

Across the board, players agreed that the removal of shifting environmental effects made the core game loop significantly more intuitive.

- Interviewees noted that without constant environmental disruptions, the match flow felt more predictable in a good way—allowing teams to plan strategies rather than reacting to sudden map hazards.
- Players stated that the previous version, while unique, risked overwhelming players with too many simultaneous variables. Several mentioned that this unpredictability could be frustrating rather than skill-expressive.

By simplifying this system, the focus now shifts toward core FPS fundamentals such as aim, positioning, rotation strategies, and coordinated team play. These are the pillars that competitive players value and can master over time. Several participants also commented that removing environmental triggers would likely make the game easier to explain to new players. Without the need to constantly clarify why the map is shifting or why the environment suddenly changes, onboarding becomes smoother and the skill curve becomes more manageable.

2. Removal of Gods and Mythical Characters

The second major revision—replacing mythological characters with fully human, historically grounded figures—received consistently positive reactions.

- One of the main criticisms in the prior interviews was the challenge of balancing “mortals versus gods.” By removing characters like Thor or Loki, the roster now feels mechanically fair and thematically consistent.
- Players also reported that a fully human cast feels more believable within an FPS framework. Rather than relying on overpowered mythological abilities, the game can now

emphasize grounded tactical tools, culturally inspired combat styles, and historically relevant skills.

Interviewees described the updated cast as more cohesive, less conceptually conflicting, and easier to picture within a competitive rule set. This change also strengthened the game's identity: rather than relying on mythology as a crutch for character uniqueness, the roster now depends on historically influenced ability design, which players viewed as an opportunity for creative and meaningful gameplay design.

New Critiques and Points for Further Development

1. Ensuring Clear Role Differentiation

With mythological extremes removed, several participants stressed the need to prevent characters from feeling too similar.

- Interviewees suggested incorporating distinct tactical roles—such as skirmishers, defenders, strategists, or marksmen—to ensure that each character has a unique purpose within a team composition.
- Some participants recommended leaning further into cultural or historical backgrounds to inform abilities, such as emphasizing unique combat styles, equipment, or military training methods.

Without careful attention to role clarity, players worried that the roster could become homogenized and reduce the strategic depth necessary for competitive play.

2. Objective Flow and Match Pacing

While the removal of map-altering mechanics made the game more readable, it also raised new questions about how pacing would be maintained.

- Players expressed wanting more information about how objectives move, reset, or escalate in intensity throughout a match.
- A few participants recommended experimenting with multiple pacing structures—such as shorter, round-based modes or longer objective-control cycles—to determine which format best supports strategic play and spectator engagement.

This was framed more as a request for clarification than a criticism, indicating that players are now able to engage with the game at a deeper mechanical level.

3. Importance of Communication Infrastructure

As with the initial interviews, experienced players emphasized the necessity of strong communication systems, especially for an FPS designed with competitive play in mind.

- Suggestions included a robust ping system, objective markers, simplified callouts, and responsive visual indicators.
- Several players pointed out that without environmental effects, readable UI becomes even more central to maintaining strategic clarity in the heat of a match.
- Participants made it clear that communication tools would not need to be finalized early, but initial prototypes should be implemented before playtesting begins.

Positive Reactions to the New Direction

1. Greater Competitive Viability

A key takeaway from the interviews is that the updated vision aligns more closely with existing esports frameworks while still offering a unique twist.

- Players appreciated that the game now emphasizes measurable skill—aiming, timing, positioning, teamwork—rather than external mechanics tied to a relic or supernatural events.
- The grounded design was viewed as “fairer,” “more learnable,” and “more sustainable” for long-term competitive growth.
- Participants felt that the revised concept would be easier for teams to scrim, analyze, and prepare strategies for, which is essential for any aspiring competitive title.

2. Stronger Thematic and Mechanical Cohesion

Interviewees also responded positively to the game’s emerging identity.

- The shift toward historically inspired characters was described as “fresh,” “distinctive,” and “less gimmicky” compared to mythological hero shooters.
- Players felt more invested in the concept because it now more confidently commits to a grounded, realistic, but creatively flexible theme.
- Several participants mentioned that this clearer identity could serve as a strong foundation for marketing and community building.

Conclusion

The post-conception interviews demonstrated that the revisions made after the initial feedback cycle significantly improved the clarity, coherence, and competitive viability of the game concept. Removing the relic-triggered environmental mechanics simplified match flow and reduced unnecessary complexity, while eliminating gods and mythological characters resolved major concerns regarding balance and thematic consistency. Remaining areas for development, such as clearly defined character roles, refined objective pacing, and communication tools, are all practical elements that can be systematically addressed through prototyping and early-stage

playtesting. Overall, players expressed that the updated direction feels more grounded, more competitive, and more achievable than the original version, and they showed increased interest in seeing the concept move toward its first playable iteration.